

Out of the abyss: On South Korea, its new President

South Korea needs to expand trade **ties** with major countries

When the then South Korean President Yoon Suk Yeol declared **martial law** in December 2024, his objective was to **bypass** the opposition-controlled National Assembly and **rule** with the support of the military. He had also planned to arrest opposition politicians, including Lee Jae-myung, the head of the Democratic Party, his **bête noire**. But the move **backfired** dramatically, **leading to** his **abrupt downfall** and **paving the way for** Mr. Lee's **ascent** to the presidency. In the June 3 election, which was **necessitated** by the **impeachment** of Mr. Yoon, Mr. Lee, a progressive liberal, won 49.4% votes, defeating Kim Moon-soo of Mr. Yoon's conservative People Power Party, who **secured** 41.2% votes. The peaceful and democratic **transition**, **following** a period of **chaos** and **turmoil**, **is** a **testament** to the strong fundamentals of South Korea's young democracy. For a nation that **endured decades of brutal military dictatorship**, the **imposition** of martial law **was tantamount to cutting open the old wounds**. **South Koreans**, both the political class and civilians, **offered resistance**. Mr. Yoon's political **collapse unfolded** so fast that future leaders would think twice before **undermining** the country's democratic institutions. Still, the election of Mr. Lee is only the first step in **restoring** order and stability.

Mr. Lee, who survived legal challenges and an **assassination** attempt last year, **enters** the Blue House with a strong **mandate**. His party is in a majority in the National Assembly, giving him legislative **leeway**. However, while those responsible for the martial law **fiasco** must be **held accountable**, he must **resist** the **temptation** to turn this into a political **witch-hunt**. On the economy front, Mr. Lee should take swift measures, including the implementation of a promised **stimulus** package to jump start growth. Just last month, the central bank cut the country's full-year economic forecast by half to 0.8% **amid** trade and tariff concerns. In foreign policy, Mr. Lee faces a complex balancing act. During the campaign, he had said that the U.S. was "the basis **axis** of our **diplomacy**", but expressed a desire to improve commercial ties with China, the largest trading partner. Under Mr. Yoon, relations with China **took a hit**, and tensions with North Korea **escalated**. In a first step to improve inter-Korean relations, Mr. Lee decided to **turn off** loudspeakers on the border that had been **broadcasting** K-pop songs and **propaganda**. He has said he does not want South Korea to be **reliant** only **on** the U.S. **To that end**, what he must do is to invest in peace on the Korean Peninsula and expand Seoul's relationship with major powers, while **preserving** its strategic partnership with the U.S. **[Practice Ex.]**

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

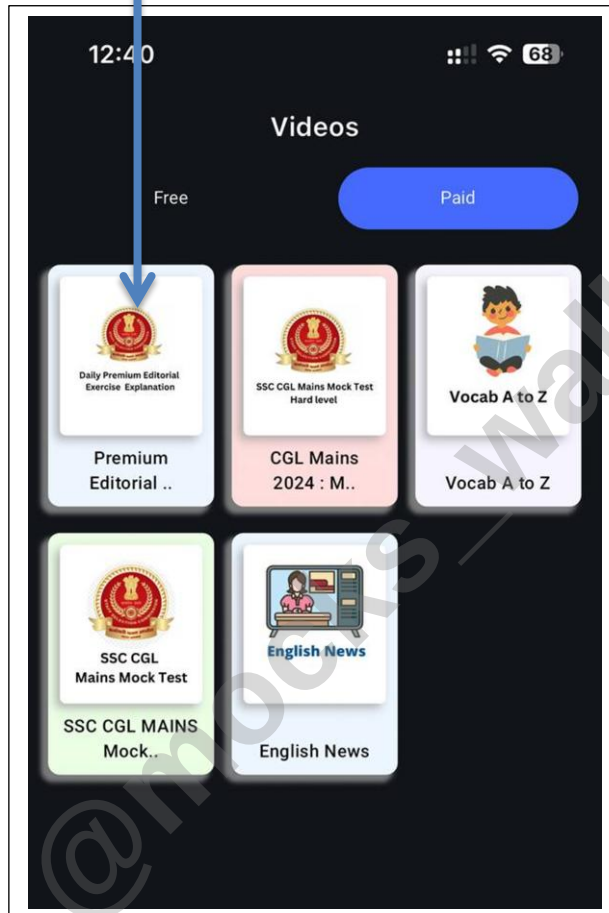
Vocabulary

1. **Abyss** (noun) – chasm, void, gulf, pit, depth
गहरा संकट
2. **Ties** (noun) – connections, relations, bonds, associations, links संबंध
3. **Martial law** (noun) – military rule, emergency rule, army control, military governance, suspension of civil authority
सैनिक कानून
4. **Bypass** (verb) – avoid, circumvent, sidestep, evade, skip टालना / नज़रअंदाज़ करना
5. **Rule** (verb) – govern, control, administer, command, direct शासन करना
6. **Bête noire** (noun) – enemy, nemesis, rival, antagonist, arch-foe घृणास्पद व्यक्ति / विरोधी
7. **Backfire** (verb) – fail, boomerang, misfire, rebound, have opposite effect उल्टा असर होना
8. **Lead** (to) (verb) – result in, cause, bring about, produce, give rise to कारण बनना
9. **Abrupt** (adjective) – sudden, unexpected, quick, immediate, hasty अचानक
10. **Downfall** (noun) – collapse, ruin, defeat, destruction, failure पतन
11. **Pave the way for** (phrase) – prepare for, open the door for, enable, make possible, lay the foundation for रास्ता बनाना
12. **Ascent** (noun) – rise, elevation, advancement, promotion, upsurge उदय / चढ़ाई
13. **Necessitate** (verb) – require, demand, entail, involve, call for आवश्यक बनाना
14. **Impeachment** (noun) – accusation, indictment, removal, prosecution, charge महाभियोग
15. **Secure** (verb) – obtain, gain, acquire, earn, achieve प्राप्त करना
16. **Transition** (noun) – change, shift, transformation, evolution, passage परिवर्तन / संक्रमण
17. **Following** (preposition) – after, subsequent to, post, ensuing, in the wake of के बाद
18. **Chaos** (noun) – disorder, confusion, anarchy, mayhem, turmoil अव्यवस्था / अफरातफरी
19. **Turmoil** (noun) – upheaval, unrest, agitation, turbulence, commotion उथल-पुथल

20. **Testament** (to) (noun) – proof, evidence, demonstration, indication, confirmation
प्रमाण
21. **Endure** (verb) – withstand, tolerate, suffer, bear, survive सहना / झेलना
22. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
23. **Brutal** (adjective) – cruel, harsh, ruthless, savage, inhumane क्रूर
24. **Dictatorship** (noun) – tyranny, autocracy, totalitarianism, despotism, authoritarianism तानाशाही
25. **Imposition** (noun) – enforcement, implementation, application, burden, infliction थोपना / लागू करना
26. **Tantamount** (to) (adjective) – equivalent, equal, comparable, synonymous, similar बराबर
27. **Cut open the old wound** (phrase) – revive pain, trigger trauma, reopen past hurt, rekindle sorrow, remind past agony पुराने घावों को कुरेदना
28. **Resistance** (noun) – opposition, defiance, protest, fightback, struggle विरोध
29. **Collapse** (noun) – breakdown, failure, downfall, ruin, crumbling पतन
30. **Unfold** (verb) – develop, emerge, happen, occur, transpire सामने आना
31. **Undermine** (verb) – weaken, sabotage, erode, impair, destabilize कमजोर करना
32. **Restore** (verb) – reestablish, reinstate, recover, bring back, revive पुनर्स्थापित करना
33. **Assassination** (noun) – killing, murder, execution, elimination, homicide हत्या (राजनीतिक या प्रसिद्ध व्यक्ति की)
34. **Mandate** (noun) – authority, command, order, authorization, approval जनादेश
35. **Leeway** (noun) – flexibility, freedom, margin, room, scope छूट / स्वतंत्रता
36. **Fiasco** (noun) – disaster, failure, debacle, collapse, mess विफलता
37. **Hold accountable** (phrase) – make responsible, charge, blame, call to account, punish ज़िम्मेदार ठहराना
38. **Resist** (verb) – oppose, withstand, reject, fight, defy विरोध करना
39. **Temptation** (noun) – urge, desire, lure, attraction, inclination प्रलोभन
40. **Witch-hunt** (noun) – persecution, harassment, scapegoating, vendetta, hunt for dissent विरोधियों की छानबीन / राजनीतिक उत्पीड़न
41. **Stimulus** (noun) – incentive, boost, spur, encouragement, impetus प्रोत्साहन

42. **Amid** (preposition) – during, among, in the middle of, while, throughout के बीच
43. **Axis** (noun) – center, pivot, core, alliance, main base धुरी / मुख्य आधार
44. **Diplomacy** (noun) – foreign policy, tact, negotiation, statesmanship, international relations कूटनीति
45. **Take a hit** (phrase) – suffer damage, be affected, face trouble, incur loss नुकसान उठाना
46. **Escalate** (verb) – intensify, increase, worsen, heighten, aggravate बढ़ना / गंभीर होना
47. **Turn off** (phrasal verb) – deactivate, shut down, power off, stop, discontinue बंद करना
48. **Broadcast** (verb) – transmit, air, telecast, relay, disseminate प्रसारण करना
49. **Propaganda** (noun) – misinformation, publicity, promotion, spin, indoctrination प्रचार
50. **Reliant** (on) (adjective) – dependent, counting on, trusting, needing, leaning on निर्भर
51. **To that end** (phrase) – therefore, for that purpose, accordingly, with that aim उस उद्देश्य के लिए
52. **Preserve** (verb) – maintain, protect, safeguard, uphold, conserve बनाए रखना / सुरक्षित रखना

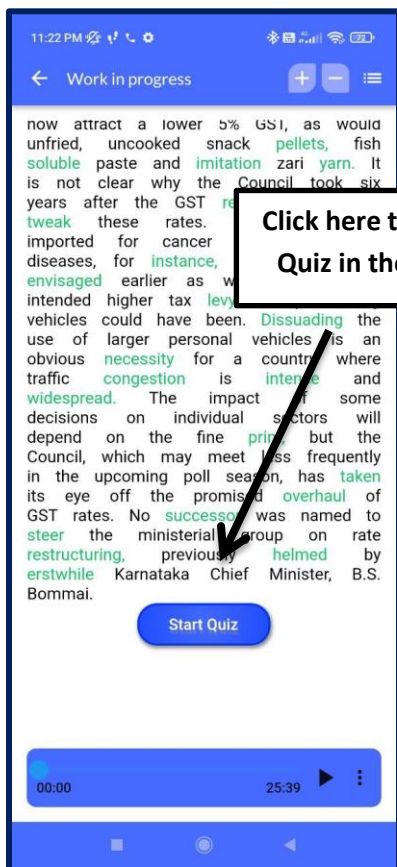
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



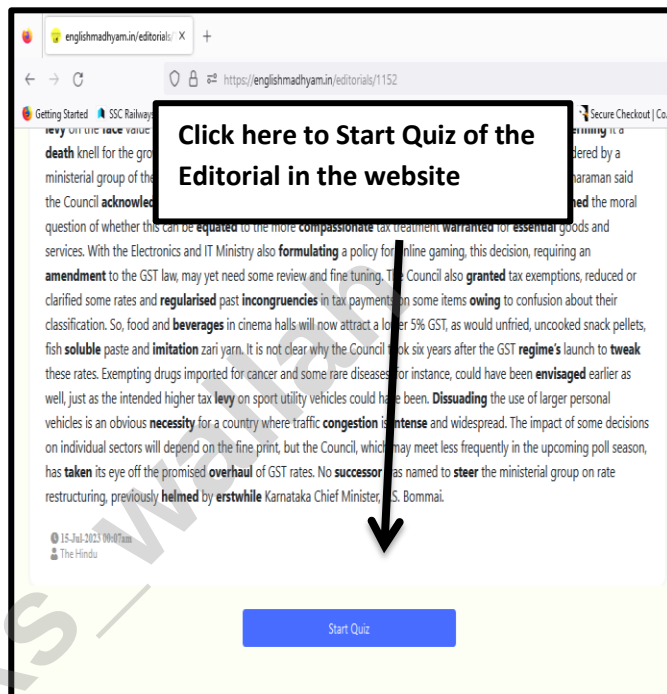
Summary of the Editorial

1. Former President Yoon Suk Yeol declared martial law in December 2024 to bypass an opposition-led National Assembly and tighten his grip on power.
2. His plan to arrest opposition leaders, including Lee Jae-myung, backfired and led to his downfall and impeachment.
3. In the June 3 election, Lee Jae-myung, a progressive liberal, won with 49.4% votes, defeating conservative Kim Moon-soo.
4. The peaceful transfer of power after political upheaval highlights the resilience of South Korea's democracy.
5. South Koreans — civilians and politicians alike — resisted the return to authoritarian tactics, recalling the nation's history of military rule.
6. Mr. Yoon's rapid collapse serves as a warning to future leaders against undermining democratic institutions.
7. Lee Jae-myung enters office with a clear mandate and parliamentary majority, providing legislative strength.
8. He must ensure accountability for the martial law crisis without turning it into a political vendetta.
9. Mr. Lee also survived legal challenges and an assassination attempt in the previous year, boosting his political credibility.
10. Economically, he needs to act quickly — especially to implement a stimulus package to counter sluggish growth.
11. South Korea's central bank recently cut growth projections to 0.8%, citing trade tensions and tariff uncertainties.
12. Mr. Lee's foreign policy challenge includes maintaining ties with the U.S. while also improving relations with China.
13. China is South Korea's largest trading partner, and ties had worsened under Yoon's administration.
14. In a symbolic move, Mr. Lee halted border loudspeaker propaganda to reduce tensions with North Korea.
15. His broader aim should be to invest in peace on the Korean Peninsula, expand global partnerships, and preserve strategic balance, especially with the U.S.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



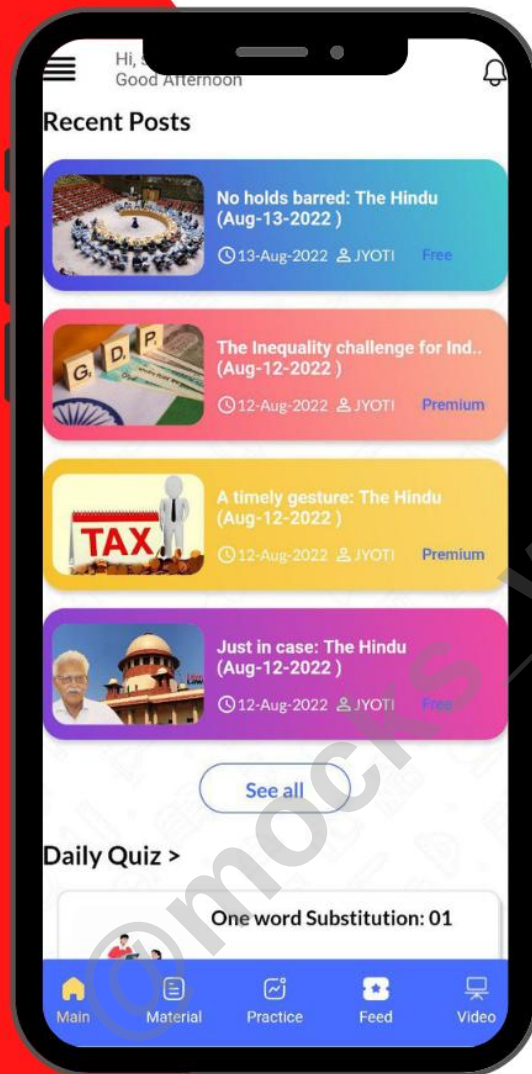
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